



A GME x CBIQ WHITE PAPER · SEPTEMBER 2026

Doing More With Less

The State of Global Mobility Under Cost Pressure

This white paper has been created following the GME x CBIQ virtual event of September 24, 2026, drawing on the pre-event survey responses from 70 Global Mobility leaders, the CBIQ benchmark of 800+ contributing organizations, and a panel discussion held under Chatham House Rules.

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Executive summary

Global Mobility is not simply being asked to spend less. It is being asked to redesign how it operates.

That is the headline from our September 2026 virtual event, where 70 Global Mobility leaders, predominantly from large global organisations with mature programs, benchmarked themselves live against the wider CBIQ dataset. The findings in five findings:

1**Cost is now number one.**

Cost is the top operational pressure for this group (49%), the first cohort in 2026 where cost has overtaken immigration and regulatory change

2**Nobody is coming to help.**

69% expect pressure on their function to increase over the next 12 months, exactly matching the wider market.

3**The measurement gap is stark.**

Across the wider benchmark, the single most common answer to "how do you measure program success" is that organizations do not formally measure it at all. Only 48 percent of the room measure ROI on moves, and across the wider market just 12 percent cite demonstrable ROI as a success measure at all.

4**The response has changed shape.**

In 2023, organizations trimmed allowances. Now the Room is focused on restructuring: automation, AI, policy redesign and vendor strategy. 54% of the Room, against 27% of the market.

5**The market is buying by tender.**

46% of the Room is in, recently through, or considering an RFP. Add those approaching a scheduled vendor review, and more than half the Room is in motion.

01 Who was in the room

Seventy leaders completed the pre-event survey, and their answers shape everything that follows.

53%

organizations of 25,000+ employees

market: 28%

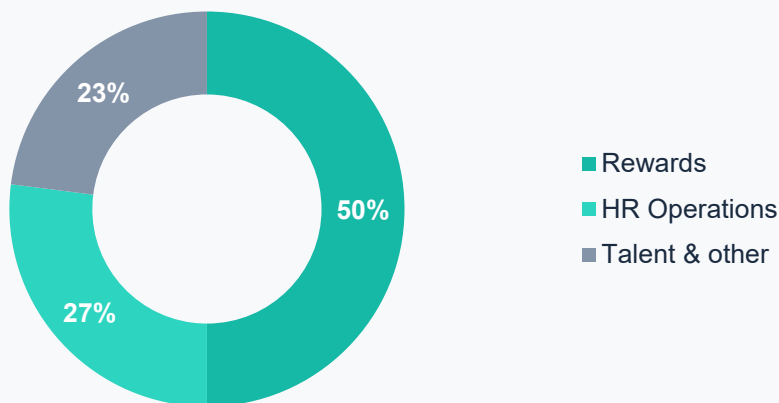
57%

North America headquartered

77%

report through Rewards or HR Operations

Where Mobility reports



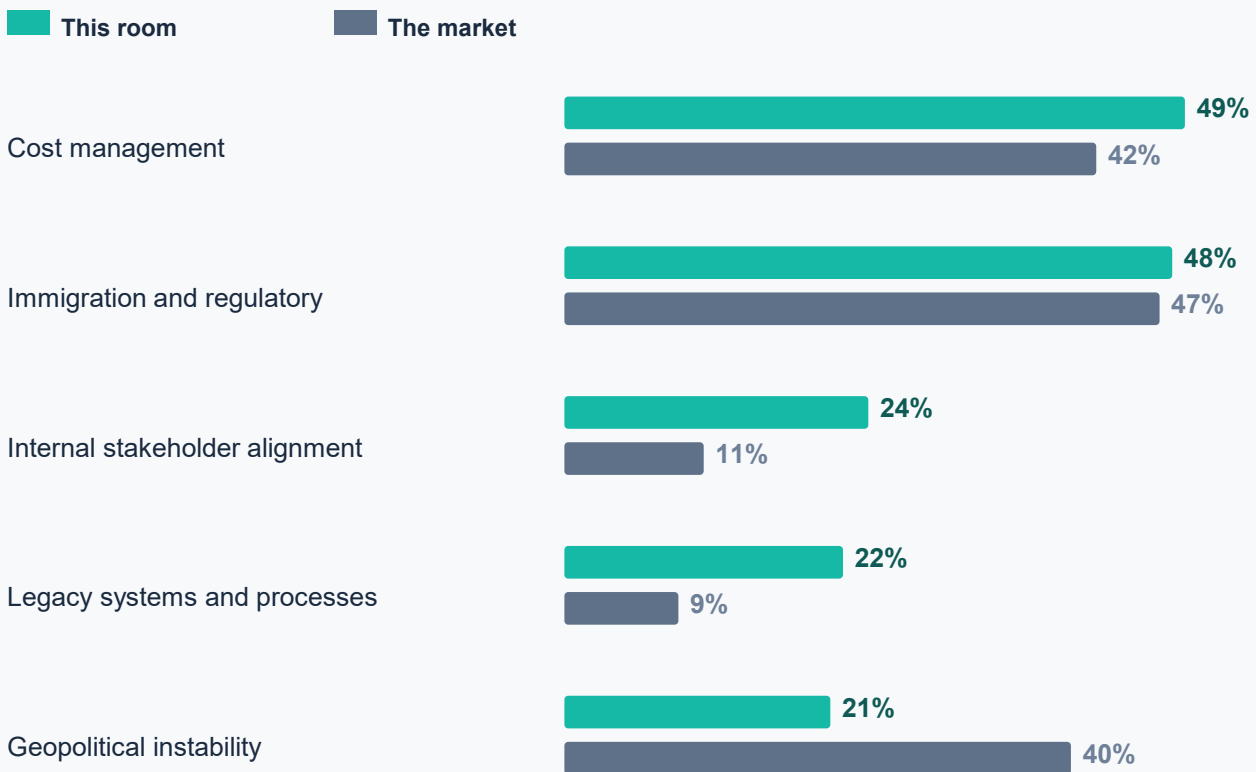
The Rewards function, alone accounts for 50 percent of reporting lines, with HR Operations at 27 percent and far fewer under Talent or other. Despite years of discussion about Mobility moving closer to talent, the function is still regarded as as being compliance and process focused and best sits under Reward.

This context frames the pressures that follow: these are large, mature programs, and even they are straining.

Room data is measured against the CBIQ benchmark of 800+ contributing organizations (Room n = 70, market n = 670).

02 The pressure map

Participants selected their top operational pressures. The room and the market largely agree on the top two, then diverge sharply:



Operational pressures (select up to 3). Comparison of: 70 room / 670 market.

Cost has drawn level with immigration at the top of the agenda.

This is the first cohort CBIQ has measured in 2026, where cost management edged out immigration as the number one pressure. The margin is narrow, but the direction is unmistakable.

The pressure is inside the building.

Internal alignment (24% vs 11%) and legacy systems (22% vs 9%) weigh on this group at more than double the market rate. The binding constraint is from internal pressures within the organisation rather than external forces.

Geopolitics is the inversion.

The only pressure the room feels substantially less than the market (21% vs 40%). Larger programs have absorbed geopolitical volatility into business as usual.

03 The squeeze ahead

69%

of the room expect pressure on their function to increase over the next 12 months.

The wider market says exactly the same: **69%**.

The symmetry is the story. Whatever an organization's size, sector, or maturity, the expectation is identical: more demands, not more resources.

“Doing more with less” is not this year's theme. It is the operating environment.

Base: 70 room / market benchmark. Both report 69%.

04 The measurement gap

For a discipline under cost pressure, Global Mobility is strikingly unable to prove its own numbers:

48%

of the room measure ROI on moves

30%

do not measure the cost of a move against budget at all

~28%

still run the program on spreadsheets and general office tools

In 2023, only one in three organizations had technology giving them true visibility of move costs. Three years on, the wider benchmark shows limited progress: 28 percent still run on spreadsheets and general office tools alone, and another 29 percent are only partially covered by technology. More than half the market still cannot fully see what a move truly costs. Just 30 percent run a dedicated Global Mobility platform.

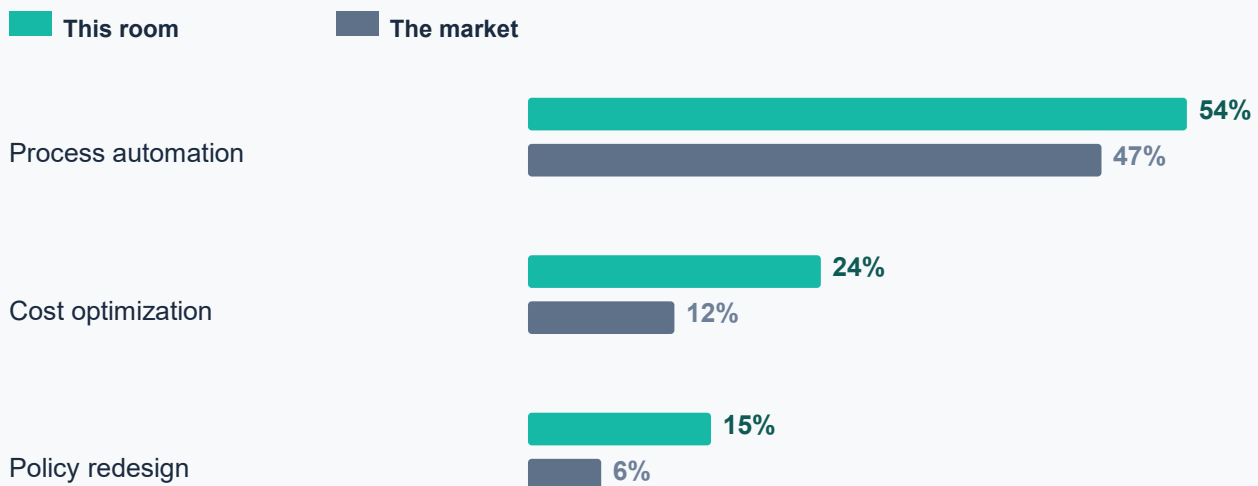
The wider benchmark deepens the point.

Asked how they measure program success, the single most common answer among contributing organizations is that they do not formally measure it at all, ahead of business-objective achievement, satisfaction scores, and cost tracking. Demonstrable ROI sits near the bottom of the list, cited by only a handful of organizations.

The implication discussed in the room: the challenge is not simply reducing spend. It is having the data and technology to understand where money is going in the first place. You cannot optimize what you cannot see.

05 Where the money goes next

Only 18 percent of the Room called their current operating model effective. The market says the same: 21 percent. This is not a Room problem or a regional one. Across 800+ organizations, leaders are delivering the same verdict on the function they themselves run. The machine needs rebuilding, not tuning. And that candor explains the investment response:



Investment priorities, next 12 to 18 months. Bases: 70 room / market benchmark.

61% have their Mobility policy under review right now. On cost optimization and policy redesign, the room moves at double the market rate.

The direction of policy redesign, discussed throughout the session: moves away from traditional long-term assignments towards permanent transfers, self-initiated moves, short-term assignments, and more flexible, personalized packages. The one-size-fits-all program is gradually being retired.

06 The RFP wave

46%

of the room is in, recently through, or considering a Global Mobility RFP. Nearly half the cohort is restructuring its cost base by tender.

The wider benchmark says this is no local phenomenon. Of the organizations asked the same question across the CBIQ dataset, more than half are in or approaching a vendor review. CBIQ's live pipeline currently tracks [82] organizations in market, from active RFPs to early consideration, across every major outsourced category.

The open question raised in the session: is this wave driven by smaller internal teams outsourcing more operational activity, by pressure on vendors to cut costs, or both? The panel's answer, in effect, was both.

RFP figure base: 70 (room). Market vendor-review question and live pipeline from the CBIQ benchmark.

07 2023 versus 2026: cost cutting grows up

GME last researched cost reduction in depth in 2023 (88 organizations, April to May 2023; a separate cohort from today's benchmark). The comparison is the clearest evidence of how the discipline has matured:

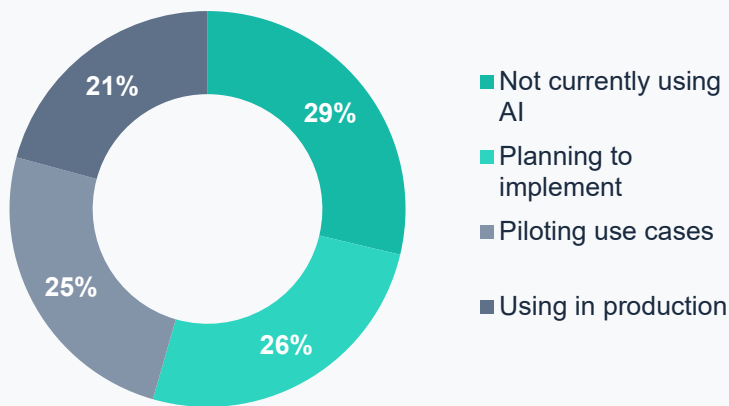
	2023	2026
Cost reduction stance	"Important or critical" for 80%	The number one operational pressure
Primary tactic	Cutting relocation expenses first (62%), then capping allowances (40%)	Automation, AI workflows, and policy redesign at double the market rate
Character of response	Trimming: temporary housing, shipping allowances, lump sums	Structural: operating models, vendor strategy, differentiated support

In 2023, organizations made moves cheaper by trimming allowances. In 2026, they are redesigning how mobility operates.

The difference matters for employees too: trimming allowances can impact a move's experience, while structural redesign aims to protect experience where it counts and removes cost where nobody notices.

08 The AI reality check

Across the current benchmark of 761 organizations answering on AI adoption:



71%

are using, piloting, or planning AI

1 in 5

has anything in production

Figures are rounded to the nearest whole number and may not sum to 100.

Read one way, 71 percent of the market is using, piloting, or planning AI. Read another, only one in five organizations has anything in production. The gap between AI conversation and AI operation remains wide, and the room's investment priorities (automation at 54 percent) suggest the next 18 months are when planning converts to production, or fails to.

AI adoption base: 761 organizations answering across the CBIQ benchmark.

09 What the leaders said

The panel, drawn from major global organizations across media, insurance, and entertainment and held under the Chatham House Rules, converged on four themes:

1 Free the team before you shrink it

“Doing more with less” should not default to cutting headcount or benefits. Automating repetitive operational work frees capacity for complex cases, governance and advisory work. One panelist's organization is targeting automation of 75% of traditional assignment administration.

2 Start with vendors, not people

Asked where they would begin if mandated to cut costs, panelists pointed first to vendor consolidation, renegotiated SLAs and pricing structures, particularly in complex categories such as immigration and tax where costs are least controlled.

3 Match support to complexity

A strong case against one-size-fits-all support. Aligning service level and vendor support with the complexity of the move creates efficiency without simply degrading the employee experience.

4 Strategy is the destination

The function's future is advisory: the operational work is what gets automated, outsourced, or tiered, and the strategic work is what justifies the function's seat at the table.

10 The playbook

Across the data, six moves separate the organizations restructuring successfully from the rest:

1 Get cost visibility first

With three in ten still on spreadsheets, the prerequisite for any credible cost program is technology that shows true move costs.

2 Measure something

Even basic cost-against-budget tracking, absent in 30% of the room, changes the function's standing in a cost conversation.

3 Automate the repetitive, protect the complex

Target the operational workload that consumes team capacity and reinvest it in governance and advisory work.

4 Tier support by complexity

Differentiate service levels and vendor involvement by the real complexity of each move rather than applying uniform support.

5 Renegotiate before you cut

Vendor consolidation, SLA renegotiation, and smarter pricing structures come before headcount or benefit reductions.

6 Redesign policy for the mobility you have

With 61% of policies under review, align policy with today's caseload: flexible, personalized packages and alternative move types.



ABOUT THE DATA

Room figures come from the pre-event survey of 70 Global Mobility leaders registered for the GME x CBIQ virtual event of September 24, 2026 (RFP figure base: 67 (slide x)). Market figures come from the CBIQ benchmark of 800+ contributing organizations (operational pressure base: 670; AI adoption base: 761). The 2023 comparison draws on the GME Cost Cutting Report, 88 organizations, April to May 2023.

Organizations contributing to CBIQ are anonymous by design; all figures are aggregates, and no named organisation will appear in CBIQ outputs.

See where you stand.

CBIQ is the live intelligence platform of the Global Mobility community: benchmark your program, see where you stand against your peers, and contribute your voice to the dataset this paper is built on.



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